

advisors. Furthermore, all women had hereditary privileges so they could pass down property and titles to their heirs.

### Marriage and divorce

During the Tang Dynasty, marriage laws gave women legal protection. Men were only allowed to take one wife (although there was no limit to the number of concubines they could buy or sell). A man could only divorce his wife under certain conditions: the failure to bear children (once the wife was 49); adultery; refusal to obey her in-laws; theft; or contracting an incurable disease. However, a man could not divorce his wife if she had married him when he was humble

and they had later become rich, or if she had no family to return to. If a husband tried to divorce under such conditions he was given 100 blows with a thick rod. If a wife tried to leave her husband without his consent, she was given two years of penal servitude.

Chinese culture overall was still patriarchal. Confucianism stressed that a woman's place was in the home, and that she was subordinate to her father, husband, or some other male relative. However, despite this view, many women in Tang China enjoyed freedoms and influence unparalleled in most other contemporary societies, meaning the country's golden age was not just limited to men.



#### BIOGRAPHY

### WU ZETIAN

Born in 624 CE, Wu Zetian was claimed as a concubine by Emperor Taizong at the age of 13. Wu rose to power by eliminating other powerful women at court; some sources even suggested that she killed her own child and framed the emperor's first wife to gain her position. After the death of Taizong's son, Gaozong, Wu quelled a revolt and usurped the throne. She ruled alone as empress until she was forced to abdicate her throne to her son in 704. Wu died just a year later.

#### ◀ Imperial ensemble

Court women play flutes during the reign of Emperor Li Yu (937–978 CE), in this detail of *The Night Revels of Han Xizai*. As well as the flute, the fiddle and another stringed instrument called the pipa were popular during the Tang Dynasty.

